

The Impact of Party Identification ◇ 6

The behavior of the American voter as presidential elector can be described initially as a response to psychological forces. The individual's attitudes toward the elements of national politics comprise a field of forces that determines his action in an immediate sense, and the field's properties account for much of the behavior we observe. In particular, the intensity of attitude helps explain why some people vote and others do not. For those who vote, the consistency of attitude reveals in part why one person casts a straight-party vote, whereas another divides his support between the parties. And most important of all, the intensity and partisan direction of attitude can account for the choice each elector will make between the rival candidates for President.

How do these forces arise? The manner in which the individual perceives and evaluates the elements of national politics may orient his behavior, but if we seek to account for the variability of these factors we confront a fresh problem of explanation. In an important sense these attitude forces are intervening variables linking behavior with a host of antecedent factors. The very success of these forces in accounting for behavior heightens the interest in locating prior factors by which the properties of individual attitude may in turn be explained. In the present chapter we consider an antecedent factor that lies still within the realm of individual psychology, and, like the proximal attitudes, is defined in political terms.

A general observation about the political behavior of Americans is that their partisan preferences show great stability between elections. Key speaks of the "standing decision" to support one party or the other, and this same phenomenon soon catches the eye of any student

of electoral behavior. Its mark is readily seen in aggregate election statistics. For virtually any collection of states, counties, wards, precincts, or other political units one may care to examine, the correlation of the party division of the vote in successive elections is likely to be high. Often a change of candidates and a broad alteration in the nature of the issues disturb very little the relative partisanship of a set of electoral units, which suggests that great numbers of voters have party attachments that persist through time.

The fact that attachments of this sort are widely held is confirmed by survey data on individual people. In a survey interview most of our citizens freely classify themselves as Republicans or Democrats and indicate that these loyalties have persisted through a number of elections. Few factors are of greater importance for our national elections than the lasting attachment of tens of millions of Americans to one of the parties. These loyalties establish a basic division of electoral strength within which the competition of particular campaigns takes place. And they are an important factor in assuring the stability of the party system itself.

The Concept and Measurement of Party Identification

Only in the exceptional case does the sense of individual attachment to party reflect a formal membership or an active connection with a party apparatus. Nor does it simply denote a voting record, although the influence of party allegiance on electoral behavior is strong. Generally this tie is a psychological identification, which can persist without legal recognition or evidence of formal membership and even without a consistent record of party support. Most Americans have this sense of attachment with one party or the other. And for the individual who does, the strength and direction of party identification are facts of central importance in accounting for attitude and behavior.

In characterizing the relation of individual to party as a psychological identification we invoke a concept that has played an important if somewhat varied role in psychological theories of the relation of individual to individual or of individual to group. We use the concept here to characterize the individual's affective orientation to an important group-object in his environment. Both reference group theory and small-group studies of influence have converged upon the attracting or repelling quality of the group as the generalized dimension most critical in defining the individual-group relationship, and it is this dimension that we will call identification. In the present chapter

the political party serves as the group toward which the individual may develop an identification, positive or negative, of some degree of intensity.

The importance of stable partisan loyalties has been universally recognized in electoral studies, but the manner in which they should be defined and measured has been a subject of some disagreement. In keeping with the conception of party identification as a psychological tie, these orientations have been measured in our research by asking individuals to describe their own partisan loyalties. Some studies, however, have chosen to measure stable partisan orientations in terms of an individual's past voting record or in terms of his attitude on a set of partisan issues. Thus Republican and Democratic identifiers are sometimes defined as those who vote consistently for the same party and "Independents" as those who do not. The fact that a definition of this sort serves many practical and scholarly purposes underscores the immense influence of party identification in motivating behavior. But we feel that such a definition blurs the distinction between the psychological state and its behavioral consequences. We have not measured party attachments in terms of the vote or the evaluation of partisan issues because we are interested in exploring the influence of party identification on voting behavior and its immediate determinants. When an independent measure of party identification is used it is clear that even strong party adherents at times may think and act in contradiction to their party allegiance. We could never establish the conditions under which this will occur if lasting partisan orientations are measured in terms of the behavior they are thought to affect.

Our measurement of party identification rests fundamentally on self-classification. Since 1952 we have asked repeated cross sections of the national population a sequence of questions inviting the individual to state the direction and strength of his partisan orientation.¹ The dimension presupposed by these questions appears to have psychological reality for virtually the entire electorate. The partisan self-image of all but the few individuals who disclaim any involvement in politics permits us to place each person in these samples on a continuum of

¹ The initial question was this: "Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a Republican, a Democrat, an Independent, or what?" Those who classified themselves as Republicans or Democrats were also asked, "Would you call yourself a strong (Republican, Democrat) or a not very strong (Republican, Democrat)?" Those who classified themselves as Independents were asked this additional question: "Do you think of yourself as closer to the Republican or Democratic Party?" The concept itself was first discussed in George Belknap and Angus Campbell, "Political Party Identification and Attitudes toward Foreign Policy," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, XV (Winter, 1952), 601-623.

partisanship extending from strongly Republican to strongly Democratic. We use the word "continuum" because we suppose that party identification is not simply a dichotomy but has a wide range of intensities in each partisan direction. In practice this range has to be represented by relatively few points, but we have devised our measures to preserve as much of the true variability as possible. The sequence of questions we have asked permits those of strong Republican or Democratic allegiance to be distinguished from those of weaker identification with one of the parties. Moreover, it allows us to distinguish the Independents who lean toward one of the parties from those who think of themselves as having no partisan coloration whatever.

The measure these methods yield has served our analysis of party identification in a versatile fashion. To assess both the direction and intensity of partisan attachments it can be used to array our samples across the seven categories shown in Table 6-1, which gives the distribution of party identification in the electorate during the years from 1952 to 1958. By treating Independents as a single group we may reduce seven categories to five. By suppressing, too, the distinction between strong and weak partisans we have a three-point scale showing only the direction of partisanship. And by "folding" the measure of party identification at its central point we have a scale showing only the strength of this psychological tie to party.

In using these techniques of measurement we do not suppose that every person who describes himself as an Independent is indicating simply his lack of positive attraction to one of the parties. Some of these people undoubtedly are actually repelled by the parties or by partisanship itself and value their position as Independents. Certainly independence of party is an ideal of some currency in our society, and it seems likely that a portion of those who call themselves Independents are not merely reporting the absence of identification with one of the major parties.

Sometimes it is said that a good number of those who call themselves Independents have simply adopted a label that conceals a genuine psychological commitment to one party or the other. Accordingly, it is argued that a person's voting record gives a more accurate statement of his party attachment than does his own self-description. Our samples doubtless include some of these undercover partisans, and we have incorporated in our measure of party identification a means of distinguishing Independents who say they lean toward one of the parties from Independents who say they do not. We do not think that the problem of measurement presented by the concealed partisan is large. Rather it seems to us much less troublesome than the problems that

TABLE 6-1. The Distribution of Party Identification

	October 1952	September 1953	October 1954	April 1956	October 1956	November 1957	October 1958
Strong Republicans	13%	15%	13%	14%	15%	10%	13%
Weak Republicans	14	15	14	18	14	16	16
Independent Republicans	7	6	6	6	8	6	4
Independents	5	4	7	3	9	8	8
Independent Democrats	10	8	9	6	7	7	7
Weak Democrats	25	23	25	24	23	26	24
Strong Democrats	22	22	22	19	21	21	23
Apolitical, don't know	4	7	4	10	3	6	5
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	1614	1023	1139	1731	1772	1488	1269

TABLE 6-2. Relation of Strength of Party Identification to Partisan Regularity in Voting for President, 1956^a

	Strong Party Identi- fiers	Weak Party Identi- fiers	Inde- pendents Leaning to Party	Inde- pendents
Voted always or mostly for same party	82%	60%	36%	16%
Voted for different parties	18	40	64	84
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	546	527	189	115

^a The question used to establish party consistency of voting was this: "Have you always voted for the same party or have you voted for different parties for President?"

follow if psychological ties to party are measured in terms of the vote.

This question can be illuminated a good deal by an examination of the consistency of party voting among those of different degrees of party identification, as is done in Table 6-2. The proportion of persons consistently supporting one party varies by more than sixty percentage points between strong party identifiers and complete Independents. For the problem of the undercover partisan, the troublesome figure in Table 6-2 is the 16 per cent of full Independents who have voted for the candidates of one party only.² The importance of this figure diminishes when we remember that some of these persons have voted in very few presidential elections and could have supported one party consistently because of the way their votes fell, free of the influence of a genuine party tie.

A simple test of this hypothesis is made in Table 6-3 by separating persons who have come of voting age relatively recently from those who have been of voting age for a greater number of elections. Plainly, the length of time a person has had to develop a variable voting record

² In this discussion we assume that the concealed partisan is less likely to distort his voting record than his description of his party attachment; that is, we assume that what the undercover partisan values is chiefly the designation "Independent." To the extent this is untrue, the analysis of voting consistency by strength of party identification fails to enhance our understanding.

TABLE 6-3. Relation of Strength of Party Identification to Partisan Regularity in Voting for President, by Age Groups, 1956

Age	Strong Party Identi- fiers	Weak Party Identi- fiers	Inde- pendents Leaning to Party	Inde- pendents
<i>21 to 34</i>				
Voted always or mostly for same party	91%	78%	60%	33%
Voted for different parties	9	22	40	67
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	104	120	53	21
<i>35 and above</i>				
Voted always or mostly for same party	80%	55%	26%	11%
Voted for different parties	20	45	74	89
Total	100%	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	440	405	136	93

influences the likelihood that he will report that he has voted for the candidates of more than one party, whatever the strength of his party identification. But among complete Independents the proportion of people thirty-five years old or older who could reasonably be called concealed party identifiers is now reduced to 11 per cent. A detailed inspection of these cases shows that a number of these individuals have voted in relatively few elections and have had little opportunity to form an inconsistent voting record. When the frequency of voting turnout is considered, the proportion of extreme Independents who have voted only for the candidates of one party is not greater than we would expect it to be by chance alone.

If Table 6-3 suggests that we will describe relatively few genuine partisans as Independents by using self-classification to measure party attachments, it also suggests some of the difficulties of trying to use voting behavior to measure psychological identifications with party. The number of votes an individual may cast in a lifetime is small. In the early years of adulthood a person has voted too few times to give a sure indication of party allegiance; and if the individual seldom goes

to the polls through the middle and later years, we have no better indication of his allegiance. And for the sensitive task of indicating *change* in these psychological identifications a simple record of behavior is clearly inadequate.

The measurement of party identification in the period of our research shows how different a picture of partisan allegiance voting behavior and self-description can give. Despite the substantial Republican majorities in the elections of 1952 and 1956, the percentages of Table 6-1 make clear that the Democratic Party enjoyed a three-to-two advantage in the division of party identification within the electorate in these same years.³ Moreover, Table 6-1 documents the stability of this division of party loyalty in a period whose electoral history might suggest widespread change. Except for the shifting size of the group of respondents refusing to be assigned any position on the party scale, there is not a single variation between successive distributions of party identification that could not be laid to sampling error.

The constancy of partisanship in the nation at large in these years implies a good deal of constancy in individual identifications with party. This implication is a loose one since the percentages of Table 6-1 show only the absence of net change in this interval of time. The similarity of these distributions may conceal a substantial volume of compensating change. To show conclusively that this is not the case we would need to have data collected through time on the party attachments of individual people. But the great stability of partisan loyalties is supported, too, by what we can learn from recall data about the personal history of party identification. We have asked successive samples of the electorate a series of questions permitting us to reconstruct whether an individual who accepts a party designation has experienced a prior change in his party identification. The responses give impressive evidence of the constancy of party allegiance.

The fact that nearly everyone in our samples could be placed on a unitary dimension of party identification and that the idea of prior movements on this dimension was immediately understood are themselves important findings about the nature of party support within the electorate. In view of the loose, federated structure of American parties it was not obvious in advance that people could respond to party in these undifferentiated terms. Apparently the positive and negative feelings that millions of individuals have toward the parties are the result of orientations of a diffuse and generalized character that have a

³ Because Republican identifiers voted with somewhat greater frequency than Democratic identifiers in these years, the Democratic edge in party allegiance was slightly less among voters.

common psychological meaning even though there may be a good deal of variation in the way party is perceived.

Party Identification and Political Attitude

The psychological function of party identification undoubtedly varies among individuals. Our interest here centers primarily on the role of party as a supplier of cues by which the individual may evaluate the elements of politics. The fact that most elements of national politics are far removed from the world of the common citizen forces the individual to depend on sources of information from which he may learn indirectly what he cannot know as a matter of direct experience. Moreover, the complexities of politics and government increase the importance of having relatively simple cues to evaluate what cannot be matters of personal knowledge.

In the competition of voices reaching the individual the political party is an opinion-forming agency of great importance. This is not to say that party leaders are able as a matter of deliberate technique to transmit an elaborate defense of their position to those in the electorate who identify with the party. To the contrary, some of the most striking instances of party influence occur with only the simplest kind of information reaching the party's mass support. For example, a party undoubtedly furnishes a powerful set of cues about a political leader just by nominating him for President. Merely associating the party symbol with his name encourages those identifying with the party to develop a more favorable image of his record and experience, his abilities, and his other personal attributes. Likewise, this association encourages supporters of the opposite party to take a less favorable view of these same personal qualities. Partisans in each camp may incorporate into their view of the candidates whatever detailed information they can, and the highly-involved may develop an elaborate and carefully-drawn portrait. But the impact of the party symbol seems to be none the less strong on those who absorb little of politics and whose image of the candidates is extremely diffuse.

Apparently party has a profound influence across the full range of political objects to which the individual voter responds. The strength of relationship between party identification and the dimensions of partisan attitude suggests that responses to each element of national politics are deeply affected by the individual's enduring party attachments. If we return to the attitude forces of Chapter 4 and examine their strength and direction across the party identification scale, a

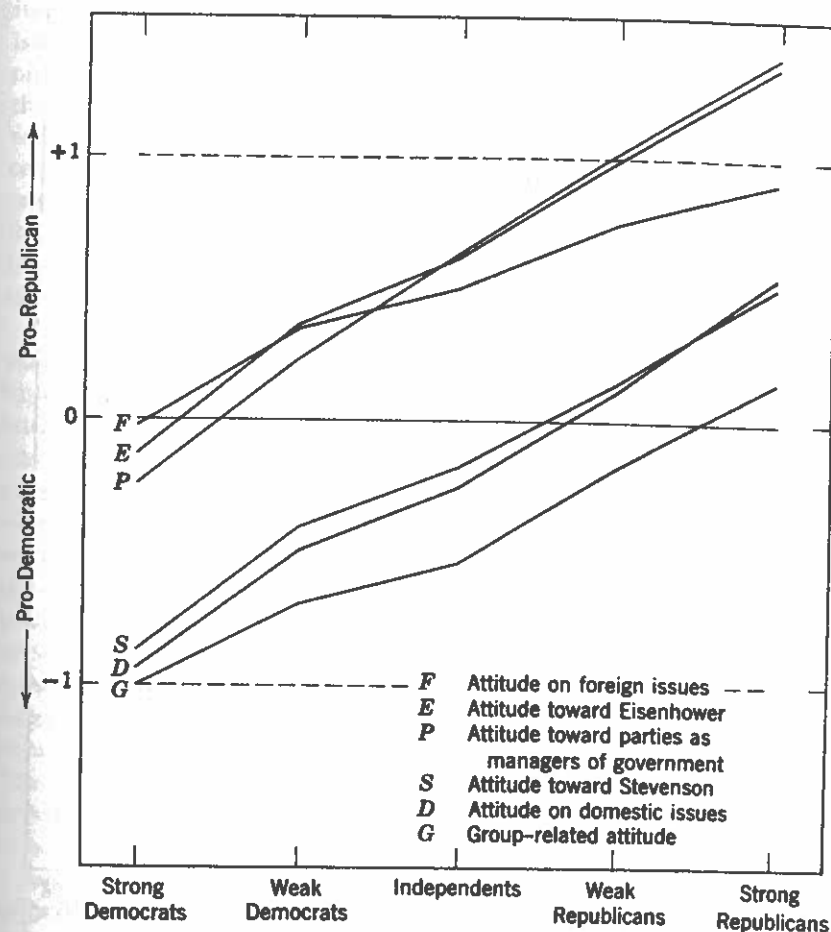


Fig. 6-1. Relation of party identification to partisan evaluations of elements of national politics, 1952.

remarkable pattern is seen. Figures 6-1 and 6-2, respectively, show this pattern as it appeared in 1952 and 1956 by displaying the mean of each attitude in each of five groups spanning the party dimension.⁴ In the design of these figures the vertical dimension indicates the inten-

⁴ In each case the mean of an attitude factor for a party identification group has been divided by the standard deviation of the factor for the group in order to express the mean in standard units about the zero point. The effect of this normalization is to lessen differences in the means that are attributable simply to differences in the number (rather than the relative partisanship) of references a party identification group has made to a given element of national politics.

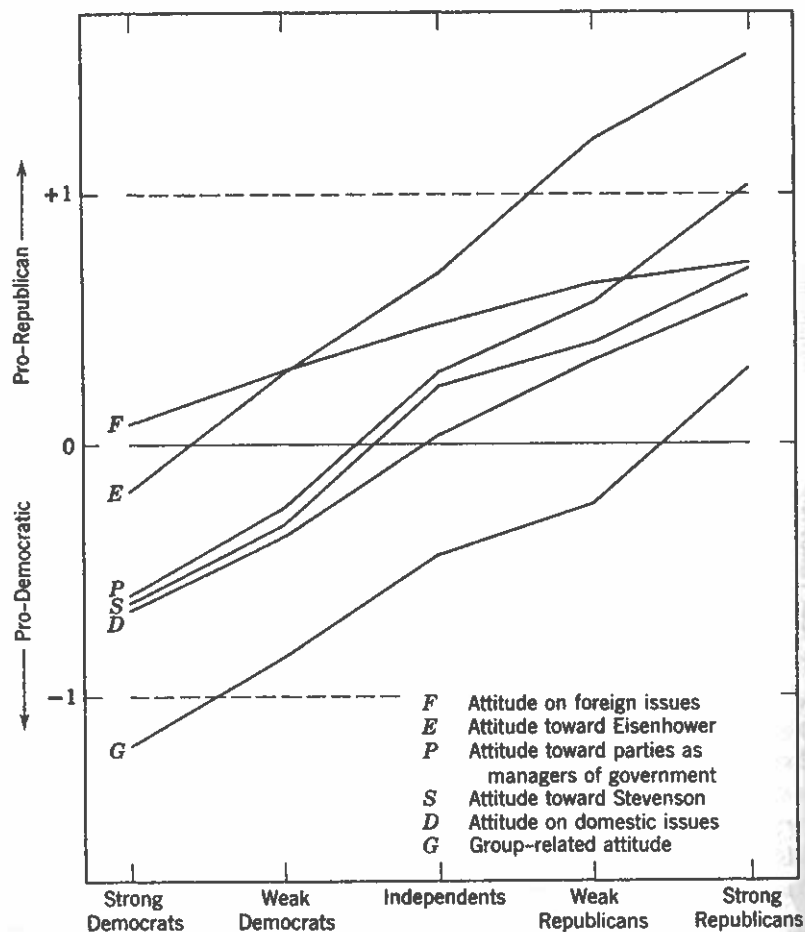


Fig. 6-2. Relation of party identification to partisan evaluations of elements of national politics, 1956.

sity and direction of attitude partisanship, the horizontal dimension the strength and direction of party identification. If we take any group along the party identification scale, it will be *more* pro-Republican in all its attitudes than the group immediately to its left and it will be *less* pro-Republican in all its attitudes than the group immediately to its right, except of course as a group may fall at the end of the party scale. The fact that without exception these attitude forces become steadily more pro-Republican as we move from the Democratic to the Republican end of the party dimension suggests the extent of the party's impact on the electorate's evaluations of the elements of pol-

itics. In both of these elections the influence of party on foreign issue attitudes seems to have been less pronounced than its influence on attitudes toward the other elements of politics. It may well be that in this period the "realities" of America's situation in the world were so clear—at least in the simple terms of which party or candidate could better preserve the peace—that there was less opportunity for partisan loyalties to form the electorate's response to the issues of foreign affairs. All the same, party identification *did* color attitudes toward foreign issues in some measure, as it colored individual feeling on every one of the dimensions of attitude we have examined.

Of course party identification cannot account for all the observed variation of political attitude. However great its impact, partisan loyalty does not by any means express the total influence of factors antecedent in a causal sense to the attitudes we have studied. Paradoxically, the very data that show the enormous influence of party allegiance on political attitude in these elections show also the limits of its explanatory power. In Figs. 6-1 and 6-2 we may note that some attitudes are more favorable than others to one of the parties *across the entire party identification scale*. For example, in each of these elections the Republicans fared better with the public on foreign issues than on domestic issues in each of the groups defined by our measure of party identification. And between the two elections this difference in attitude partisanship diminished in every one of these groups by a lessening of pro-Democratic feeling on domestic policy. These findings plainly have to be explained in terms of antecedent causal factors whose effects were independent of what is measured by our party identification scale.

Another aspect of the data from which Figs. 6-1 and 6-2 were prepared shows the limits of party identification as an explanatory factor, although this limitation cannot be seen in the figures as they are drawn. These charts describe the attitude partisanship of persons within the several party identification groups by showing averages for the groups. But each of these averages has associated with it a set of individual scores, which would lie above and below the mean values if they were shown in the figures. And this variability of individual people about the group means cannot be explained by party identification itself.⁵ Later chapters of this book will touch upon several antecedent factors

⁵ Part of this variation within groups may result from putting in a few discrete categories a population that really is spread out at many more points along an underlying dimension of party loyalty. The effects of grouping cannot explain the full variability within groups, since the individual scores of different groups "overlap."

that help to account for differences of political attitude which party identification cannot itself explain.

In the elections described by our data, party identification could not account for all aspects of the image formed by the public of the elements of national politics; but it gives to this image a central partisan coherence. The dimensions of attitude we have considered were bound together by the common influence of identifications with party. The extent to which this was true may be seen by examining directly the partisan coherence that is found within this system of attitudes in these years. Instead of inspecting the relation of each attitude dimension to party identification, in the manner of Figs. 6-1 and 6-2, we may assess the importance of a common partisan factor by examining the interrelationships of these attitudes themselves.

When this assessment is made, a common partisan factor is found to explain a large part of the variation of attitude. The full implication of the results of this analysis is not easily expressed in words, for reasons that the controversial history of the statistical techniques we have used may serve to make clear. But the examination of these interrelationships does yield a single partisan factor that could explain nearly half of the total variance of attitudes toward the elements of presidential politics among those who voted in the elections of 1952 and 1956.⁶ Moreover, the relation of this common partisan component to each type of attitude was quite high, although as we would expect from Figs. 6-1 and 6-2, its relation to foreign issue attitude was somewhat less strong. In these results the ability of a general partisan orientation to color evaluations of current political objects seems impressive.

If party identification deeply influences the partisan character of a field of psychological forces, it also will have marked effects on the

⁶ This examination was by the methods of principal component analysis due to Hotelling. See Harold Hotelling, "Analysis of a Complex of Statistical Variables into Principal Components," *Journal of Educational Psychology*, XXIV (1933), pp. 417-441, 498-520. The correlation among voters of each attitude variable with the component we interpret as a party factor is given below:

	1952	1956
Attitude toward Stevenson	0.74	0.69
Attitude toward Eisenhower	0.74	0.70
Group-related attitude	0.60	0.67
Attitude on domestic issues	0.69	0.63
Attitude on foreign issues	0.54	0.46
Attitude toward parties as managers of government	0.70	0.65

internal consistency of the field. Our conception of the role of partisan loyalties leads us to expect this result. Identification with a party raises a perceptual screen through which the individual tends to see what is favorable to his partisan orientation. The stronger the party bond, the more exaggerated the process of selection and perceptual distortion will be. Without this psychological tie, or perhaps with commitments to symbols of another kind, the Independent is less likely to develop consistent partisan attitudes.

The earlier discussion of attitude conflict is readily extended to give empirical support to this view. As in the measurement of consistency used there, we will take a person's attitudes toward the several elements of politics to be fully consistent here if each attitude that is not politically neutral has the same partisan direction. The importance of party identification for the consistency of this field of forces is quite clear if the relative incidence of attitude consistency is examined among those of different degrees of attachment to party, as it is in Table 6-4 (next page). For the four groups defined by strength of party identification the table compares the number of people who have consistent attitudes that we would "expect" to find in the group, with the number actually found. The notion of expected number is introduced here to allow for the fact that we would expect some consistency by chance and that the fewer the number of partisan attitudes a person has, the greater the likelihood he will exhibit a consistent attitude structure simply by chance. The entries of Table 6-4 show the great significance of party identification for the internal consistency of attitude. If the number of people we would expect to have consistent attitudes by chance is taken as a suitable zero, a slight tendency toward consistent partisanship is seen even among extreme Independents. But the tendency is much more marked among Independents who lean toward one of the parties and among weak party identifiers, and it is vastly greater among those who describe their party allegiance as strong.

The patterns of relationship found in cross-sectional data ought not to suggest too simple an idea of the connection between party identification and attitudes toward the elements of politics. A relation that may appear static and unidirectional in data of this sort is undoubtedly fairly complex, and several more things need to be said about it if our formulation is to do justice to psychological realities. In particular, it should be clear that the influence of party identification on attitudes toward political objects extends through time. The relationships found in the interviews of a relatively brief campaign period reflect a process of opinion formation and change that may

TABLE 6-4. Party Identification as an Influence on Partisan Consistency of Attitude, 1956^a

	Strong Party Identi- fiers	Weak Party Identi- fiers	Inde- pendents Leaning to Party	Inde- pendents
Number expected to have consistent attitudes	107	122	47	31
Number observed to have consistent attitudes	358	259	94	43
Increase of observed over expected number	235%	112%	100%	39%
Number of cases	597	558	230	117

^a This tabulation includes only individuals having at least two non-neutral attitudes; that is, only respondents for whom the notion of consistent or inconsistent attitude could be given meaning. For two, three, four, five, or six non-neutral attitudes the probabilities of someone having attitude consistency by chance alone are easily calculated, assuming the probability is 0.5 that a particular attitude will have a given partisan sign. The probabilities so calculated may be combined with what we know about the number of people in each of the four party identification groups who have each of the possible numbers of non-neutral attitudes. From this combination we obtain the number of people of each degree of party identification that we would expect to have consistent attitudes by chance. The difference between these expected frequencies and the actual frequencies of consistent individuals in each group seems an appropriate statistic for assessing the importance of strength of party identification as an influence on consistency of attitudes.

go back over many months or years. Hence the explanatory problem we confront is a dynamic one; we need to understand the causal priorities of a process extending through time and not just the direction of influence at a given moment. It seems likely that at the peak of a presidential campaign the causal relation of party identification to attitudes toward the things that are seen in national politics is two-directional. If the individual has formed attitudes that are consistent with his party allegiance, that allegiance will continue to support the attitudes it has shaped. But these attitudes in turn comprise an important defense of the individual's fixed partisan commitment, one that may well give service in discussions with face-to-face associates during the campaign. If the individual has developed attitudes *not*

consistent with his party allegiance, that allegiance presumably will work to undo the contrary opinions. But they in turn must exert some pressure on the individual's basic partisan commitment. If this pressure is intense enough, a stable partisan identification may actually be changed. When such a change occurs in a considerable part of the electorate, as it has at rare moments of our political history, the great realignments occur that change the course of electoral politics for years to come.

Therefore, an adequate account of the relation of party identification to the attitudes we have considered must allow for the fact that attitudes of this sort, when they agree with party allegiance, help to conserve this partisan tie; and when they disagree with party allegiance, are potential agents of change in the individual's basic partisan orientation. But this does not alter our judgment that in the period of our studies the influence of party identification on attitudes toward the perceived elements of politics has been far more important than the influence of these attitudes on party identification itself. We are convinced that the relationships in our data reflect primarily the role of enduring partisan commitments in shaping attitudes toward political objects. Our conviction on this point is rooted in what we know of the relative stability and priority in time of party identification and the attitudes it may affect. We know that persons who identify with one of the parties typically have held the same partisan tie for all or almost all of their adult lives. But within their experience since coming of voting age many of the elements of politics have changed. For example, the 1952 campaign brought two new candidates to presidential politics and a set of issues arising very recently from the Korean War and the charges of corruption during the later Truman years. Yet the reactions to the personalities of Eisenhower and Stevenson, to the issues of the Far Eastern war, and to the probity of the Democratic Administration differed markedly according to the individual's party allegiance. If we are to trust the evidence on the stability of party identification, these differences must be attributed to the capacity of a general partisan orientation to color responses to particular political objects.

What is more, even the elements of politics that carry over from one election to another may be evaluated anew in later campaigns by part of the electorate. The involvement of many Americans in politics is slight enough that they may respond *de novo* to issues and personalities that have been present in earlier elections but that are salient to them only at the height of a presidential campaign. For many voters the details of the political landscape may be quite blurred

until they are brought more into focus during the campaign period. The formative influence of party identification on these re-evaluations would not be essentially different from its influence on responses to newer elements of politics.

Because the influence of party identification extends through time, its workings cannot be fully disclosed by the relationships seen at a particular moment. For this reason, our statement of causal priorities is in the end an inference, but one for which the evidence is strong. If the inference is correct, the differences in attitude between those of differing partisan loyalties enlarge considerably our understanding of the configuration of forces leading to behavior. We have seen in Chapter 4 that the voting act can be explained in an immediate sense by the strength and direction and consistency of attitudes toward the political objects this act touches. We find now that an important part of the variation in the partisanship and internal coherence of these attitudes may in turn be accounted for by stable partisan identifications.

This causal paradigm requires one additional amendment. Our hypothesis that party identification influences the voting act by influencing attitudes toward the objects to which this act relates needs to be modified for the person who has only the faintest image of these objects. If someone has little perception of the candidates, of the record of the parties, of public issues or questions of group interest, his attitudes toward these things may play a less important intervening role between party identification and the vote. Presumably, among people of relatively impoverished attitude who yet have a sense of partisan loyalty, party identification has a more direct influence on behavior than it has among people with a well-elaborated view of what their choice concerns. Like the automobile buyer who knows nothing of cars except that he prefers a given make, the voter who knows simply that he is a Republican or Democrat responds directly to his stable allegiance without the mediating influence of perceptions he has formed of the objects he must choose between.

Party Identification and Electoral Choice

If some voters respond directly to a lasting sense of party identification, the behavior of most of the electorate is better explained as a response to current evaluations of what they are acting toward. We have conceived these evaluations as a field of attitude forces whose strength and direction and mutual consistency determine behavior in

an immediate sense. The role of party identification seems primarily to be that of an antecedent factor that colors these attitudes as they are formed. By no means is party the only antecedent: this field of psychological forces reflects the influence of a great range of prior factors, which may at times lead the individual to form attitudes inconsistent with his stable party attachment. But the role of general partisan orientations in molding attitudes toward the elements of politics is very clear.

As a consequence of this role, party identification has a profound impact on behavior. A sense of its impact may be gained if we return to the statistical model used in Chapter 4 to express the probability that a given individual would vote in a given partisan direction. From the strength and direction of attitudes toward the various elements of politics we could order the individuals in our samples according to the probability of their voting Republican. That is, we could form an array extending from those most likely to vote Democratic to those most likely to vote Republican. Let us now make explicit the impact party identification has on behavior through its influence on attitude, by showing a separate array for each of five groups defined by our party identification scale. For each of the distributions shown in Fig. 6-3 the

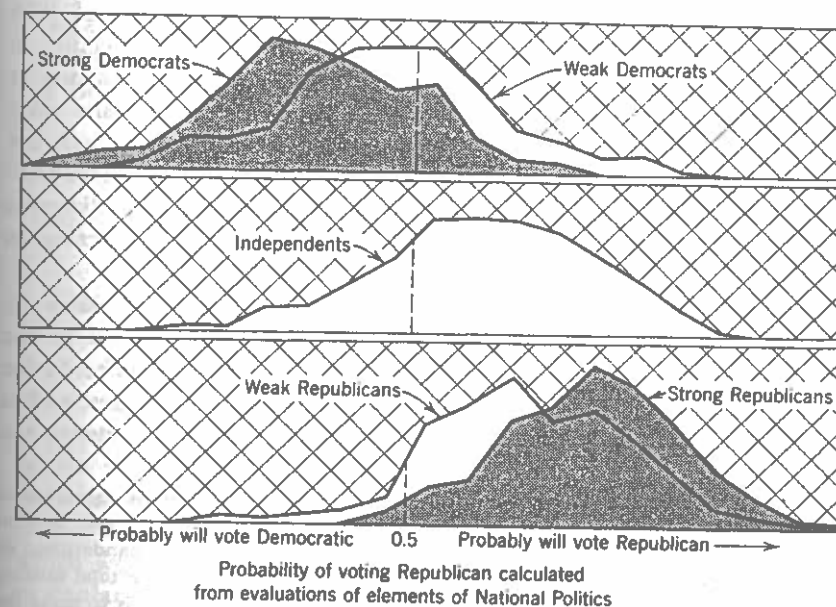


Fig. 6-3. Probable direction of vote by party identification groups, 1956.

horizontal dimension is the probability an individual will vote Republican: to the left this probability is low (that is, the likelihood the individual will vote Democratic is high) and to the right the probability that the individual will vote Republican is high.⁷ The effect of party is seen at once in the changing location of the distributions along this probability dimension as we consider successively Strong Democrats, Weak Democrats, Independents, Weak Republicans, and Strong Republicans. The moving positions of these arrays show clearly the impact of party identification on the forces governing behavior.

The properties of Fig. 6-3 serve also to demonstrate once again that party allegiance is not the sole determinant of the attitudes supporting behavior. We may attribute to the influence of party identification the movement from left to right of the centers of the arrays as we proceed from Strong Democrats to Strong Republicans. But we cannot attribute to party attachments the spread of these distributions about their centers. The probabilities we have calculated vary widely within each of the party identification groups, indeed widely enough that in some cases persons identified with one party are shown to be inclined by their attitudes to vote for the opposite party. However, the extent to which attitudes toward political objects contradicted party ties was not equal for the two parties, and this is a second aspect of these data that party allegiance cannot itself explain. In the election of 1956 all five of these arrays were "biased" in the Republican direction in the sense that many fewer strong or weak Democrats than strong or weak Republicans are seen to be probable voters for the opposite party and fewer Independents are probable Democratic voters than are probable Republican voters. Evidently in this election powerful antecedent factors other than party allegiance influenced in a direction favorable to the Republican Party the psychological forces acting on behavior.

The distributions of Fig. 6-3 foreshadow the division of the presidential vote within the several party identification groups in the election of 1956. In view of the dependence of voting choice on the psychological forces we have treated, these probability arrays lead us to expect extreme differences in the division of the vote across the

⁷ As stated on page 73, the probabilities are computed as a linear regression of the six attitude factors we have measured. To simplify the comparisons between party identification groups the distributions of Fig. 6-3 have been standardized by expressing the frequencies of probability values as percentages of the total number of individuals within each group. The effect of this transformation is to make the area of each of the five curves approximately the same.

party groups. And they lead us to expect, too, that the Republican Party had an advantage in this election in securing the votes of Independents and of persons identifying with the opposite party. Both these expectations are confirmed by Table 6-5. In the elections of 1952 and 1956 the Democratic percentage of the vote for President varied from 1 per cent among Strong Republicans to approximately 85 per cent among Strong Democrats. And the Republican candidate fared better than his Democratic opponent in attracting Independent votes and the votes of those identified with the opposite party, an advantage that was indispensable to each of his victories.

TABLE 6-5. Relation of Party Identification to Presidential Vote

	Strong Demo- crats	Weak Demo- crats	Inde- pendents	Weak Repub- licans	Strong Repub- licans
1952					
Republican	16%	38%	67%	94%	99%
Democratic	84	62	33	6	1
	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	262	274	269	171	199
1956					
Republican	15%	37%	73%	93%	99%
Democratic	85	63	27	7	1
	100%	100%	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	286	270	305	194	211

Differences in the motivational forces acting on voters of contrasting party loyalties lead us to expect wide differences between party groups in the division of the presidential vote. Yet the variability of the vote shown in Table 6-5 is so extreme that it naturally raises the question of whether party identification does not have a residual effect on behavior apart from its impact through the attitudes it influences so profoundly. That this residual effect is small is indicated by the fact that adding party identification to the set of attitude variables from which we have predicted behavior brings only a slight improvement in explanation in either the sense of statistical estimation or of the discrimination of actual Republican voters from actual Democratic

voters.⁸ The improvement that is found we attribute primarily to the role of party identification in motivating directly the behavior of persons who are without a well-developed image of the things to which their vote relates. For them, the connection of party identification and behavior may not be mediated by attitudes toward the political objects this behavior concerns. As a result, knowing their stable partisan loyalties improves our ability to predict behavior more than it does for individuals who have formed stronger evaluations of the things toward which the vote is directed.

The nature of this difference—and of our conception of the place of party identification in the forces leading to the vote—can be made clearer if we examine the behavior of individuals whose attitudes toward the current elements of politics contradict their sense of party identification. To enlarge the number of cases we may inspect, let us combine into the single array shown in Fig. 6-4 the probabilities of voting Republican we have calculated on the basis of attitude forces for every voter in our 1952 and 1956 samples. Near the center of this array we may define an interval of relatively slight partisan attitude

⁸ Incorporating party identification in the statistical model used for prediction in Chapter 4 increases the multiple correlation with voting choice from 0.72 to 0.74 in the election of 1952 and from 0.71 to 0.73 in the election of 1956. In each year the addition of this factor raises less than 2 per cent the number of persons who could be correctly classified as Republican or Democratic voters. However, it will be clear from the argument that follows that the degree to which prediction is improved would be somewhat greater among those of relatively slight attitude formation.

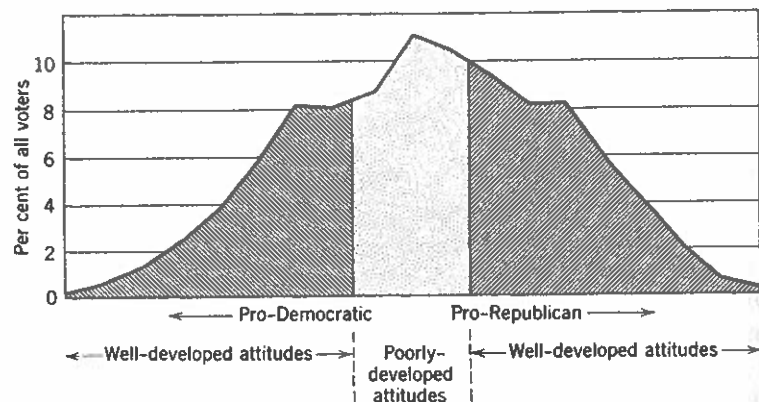


Fig. 6-4. Location of individuals with well-developed attitudes and poorly-developed attitudes within distribution of all respondents, 1952 and 1956.

formation in which lie people whose perceptions of the elements of presidential politics are either little-developed or without a clear evaluative tone. This group is represented by the lighter area in the figure. Outside this interval lie the people whose attitudes are better formed in a partisan sense and of greater motivational force. The boundaries of the interval are of course somewhat arbitrarily chosen, but if we have conceived the role of party identification correctly we ought to find that a disagreement of party allegiance and attitudes toward current political objects has very different consequences for those who lie outside this interval and for those who lie within it. In persons of strong attitude we would expect voting behavior to follow these attitudes, whatever the individual's sense of party allegiance might be. Of course, the influence of party identification on perceptions of political objects is so great that only rarely will the individual develop a set of attitude forces that conflicts with this allegiance. But when other antecedent factors lead to evaluations of the elements of politics that strongly contradict the individual's party identification, we anticipate that behavior will conform to these evaluations rather than to party allegiance. In contrast, we anticipate that when party identification is found to disagree with attitudes toward political objects formed by people whose attitudes are less numerous or motivationally weak, party allegiance will have a larger influence on behavior. Even among people of this sort evaluations of objects to which the vote relates may play an intervening role between party allegiance and behavior that is important enough to cause the individual to act against his party identification when it fails to agree with current attitude. But we would expect party allegiance to have a greater direct influence on behavior among people who have little perception of the things their behavior concerns than it has among people with a more developed or evaluatively toned view of these things.

These ideas are supported by the entries of Table 6-6, which compares the behavior of persons outside and inside our interval of limited attitude formation whose attitudes are found to disagree with their sense of party identification. Among those who have a strong evaluative image of the elements of presidential politics, behavior coincides with these evaluations in 80 per cent of the cases. The fact that party allegiance prevails in only one-fifth of these cases is the more remarkable if we keep in mind the very strong relationship of party identification to the vote across the electorate as a whole. Among those who have a less clear evaluative image of the objects of politics, behavior coincides with party identification in a much greater pro-

TABLE 6-6. Relation of Degree of Attitude Development to Direction in which Conflict of Party Identification and Partisan Evaluations Is Resolved in Voting^a

	Those Who Have Formed Evaluations		Those Who Have Formed No Evaluations At All
	That Are Well-Developed	That Are Poorly-Developed	
Vote agrees with party identification	20%	47%	75%
Vote fails to agree with party identification	80	53	25
Total	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	143	164	36

^a Figures in this table are based on a combination of data from the 1952 and 1956 election samples.

portion of cases. For these people the relation of party allegiance to behavior does seem to be mediated less by evaluations of political objects, although a good half of even these persons act in accord with the evaluations they have formed, rather than in accord with their party loyalties. Table 6-6 also describes the behavior of the very small group of individuals in our samples who identify with one of the parties yet who appear on our standard measures to have no perceptions of current political objects whatever. This is the group for which we would expect the causal sequence connecting party allegiance, attitudes toward the elements of politics, and the voting act to be most severely truncated. With evaluations of political objects playing no apparent intervening role between partisan allegiance and behavior, 75 per cent of these people simply vote their party loyalties at the polls.

Party Identification and Political Involvement

Evidently no single datum can tell us more about the attitude and behavior of the individual as presidential elector than his location on a dimension of psychological identification extending between the two

great parties. Yet our discussion of the impact of party identification should not close without some consideration of the relation of party allegiance to the dimension of political involvement introduced in Chapter 5. It is not accidental that the individual's general partisan orientation and the extent of his involvement in politics, either of which may influence a wide set of attitudinal and behavioral characteristics, are related to each other. Although our causal understanding of this relation is far from sure, the fact of association is clear enough: the stronger the individual's sense of attachment to one of the parties, the greater his psychological involvement in political affairs.

The association is easily missed in popular accounts of electoral behavior.⁹ The ideal of the Independent citizen, attentive to politics, concerned with the course of government, who weighs the rival appeals of a campaign and reaches a judgment that is unswayed by partisan prejudice, has had such a vigorous history in the tradition of political reform—and has such a hold on civic education today—that one could easily suppose that the habitual partisan has the more limited interest and concern with politics. But if the usual image of the Independent voter is intended as more than a normative ideal, it fits poorly the characteristics of the Independents in our samples. Far from being more attentive, interested, and informed, Independents tend as a group to be somewhat less involved in politics. They have somewhat poorer knowledge of the issues, their image of the candidates is fainter, their interest in the campaign is less, their concern over the outcome is relatively slight, and their choice between competing candidates, although it is indeed made later in the campaign, seems much less to spring from discoverable evaluations of the elements of national politics.

These differences may be illustrated in terms of two of the measures of involvement used in Chapter 5. When those of strong partisan identifications are compared with those who call themselves Independents, the partisan tends both in his interest in the campaign and his concern over the outcome to be more involved than the political Independent, as Tables 6-7 and 6-8 indicate. What is more, a further division of the Independent group would show in each case that those who refused to say they were closer to one party or the other are even

⁹ But it has been found by other investigators of voting behavior. See Bernard Berelson, Paul F. Lazarsfeld, and William N. McPhee, *Voting: A Study of Opinion Formation in a Presidential Campaign* (University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 1954), pp. 25-27, and Robert Agger, "Independents and Party Identifiers: Characteristics and Behavior in 1952," *American Voting Behavior*, ed. Eugene Burdick and Arthur G. Brodbeck (The Free Press, Glencoe, Ill., 1959).

less involved than other Independents. It is of course true that the percentages of Tables 6-7 and 6-8 are group proportions and that some of the Independents in our samples are highly involved. But these individuals are rare enough that the characteristics of Independents as a group are widely different from those suggested by the familiar stereotype.

TABLE 6-7. Relation of Strength of Party Identification to Interest in Campaign, 1956

	Strong Party Identifiers	Weak Party Identifiers	Independents
Very much interested	42%	23%	25%
Somewhat interested	38	42	43
Not much interested	20	35	32
Total	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	624	651	415

TABLE 6-8. Relation of Strength of Party Identification to Concern over Outcome, 1956

	Strong Party Identifiers	Weak Party Identifiers	Independents
Care very much or care pretty much	82%	62%	51%
Don't care very much or don't care at all	18	38	49
Total	100%	100%	100%
Number of cases	609	621	395

It is by no means clear what causal interpretation should be given the association of strength of party identification and degree of political involvement found in the interviews taken at single points in time. For the moment we may suppose that a person's location on either of these fundamental dimensions will influence his location on the other. The individual who has a strong and continuing involvement in politics is more likely to develop a commitment to one or the other of the major parties. And the individual who has such a commitment is likely to have his interest and concern with politics sustained at a

higher level. But we may suppose, too, that the relation of partisanship and involvement is to be explained in part by common antecedents. Discovering what it is in the individual's life experience that could account both for his party allegiance and his political involvement leads naturally to a consideration of the development of party identification.